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COL-310001

Papaya and Predators

Cemetery near Heartfelt Home

The air is damp with rain, leaving a slick dew on the leaves of a papaya tree, which shades the unkempt cemetery.

At the first toll of the funeral bell, everyone turns to the distant tower commemorating the Dragon-Slayer.

Except for Colonel Bastos, who stands at the end of the line.

Colonel: Papayas. I had thought this tree might never bear fruit.

None of those present could be said to be any younger than the one they'd laid to rest.

Elder I: What a dreadful season.

Elder II: You're not kidding ... it's been so damp and stifling. I feel like it's boiling my brain.

Old Quitéria: Hang in there. Remember, Nala made her special sweet and savory snacks today. They'll be waiting for us back at the home.

Elder I: Sweet and savory? So, she'll be serving burnt bananas or sweet potatoes, or will it be my favorite her "jawbreaker" cassava fritters.

Elder III: Ha-ha-ha, thank your lucky stars for her; she was sent from above like an angel. So what if she bumped her head along the way down?

Elder II: Did you hear her singing in the kitchen at four-thirty this morning?

Elder I: It wasn't too loud at least—She tried to be quiet. Was she already up making breakfast at that hour?

Old Quitéria: Making breakfast? I can only imagine the state of the kitchen!

Elder I: You shouldn't pile so much on her. She's bound to slip up sometimes with all that she does.

Elder II: You say that, but she's always the first to jump in when she sees something to do. And if I even try to stop her, she gets mad.

Elder II: Just like my little Ila. Ahh, she was so full of energy back then.

Old Quitéria: She was such a lovely child. I remember how her dark hair shimmered like silk in the sunlight.

Old Quitéria: Too bad Old Cinder will never get to enjoy Nala's hot bean porridge again.

The elders turn their gaze to the nearby grave. One lets out a small soft sigh.

The wooden coffin, suspended by hemp ropes, is lowered into the ground. And the first shovel of dirt is dumped on its lid.

Wild grassroots intertwine around the headstone, where the once unruly bougainvillea has been replaced by funeral lilies.

Colonel Bastos turns his singular eye to Nala, who is pushing a wheelchair. He joins her at the end, as they lay down the last flowers.

Colonel: How does my hair look? Took me half an hour to get it just right.

Anjo Nala: Don't worry, Colonel, your hair's holding up fine.

Anjo Nala: —But ...

Nala looks up at the sky.

Anjo Nala: Is he watching over us from up there?

She thinks for a moment, then quietly waves upward.

Anjo Nala: Here we are, Old Cinder.

Lilies cover the freshly dug soil. The soul within awaits their song.

Old Quitéria props up her accordion. As the colonel often says, a good accordion is never in bad taste.

Just as they have some many times before, they sing one more song for their departed friend.

The Caregivers: Joyful, beautiful, my homeland,

The Caregivers: Under a lone canoe in the night sky, I long for that eternal river,

The Caregivers: Are there swaying palms there, are there robins singing?

The Caregivers: Sleep now, oh traveler, in your homesick dreams, you'll bring joy to your family.

Anjo Nala: May he rest in peace.

Crowd: May he rest in peace.

Colonel: After all these years, Old Cinder is the first of us to go.

Colonel: Who still remembers him leading from the front—across all four thousand miles. By the end of it, his boots were so caked up they were as heavy as lead.

Colonel: Always have to be ahead of us—even when it comes to death.

Elder II: Maybe we can hold a spirit-calling ceremony for him in a few weeks.

Elder I: Not another one of your "ceremonies." Last time you messed it up, and that spirit kept bothering us for hours! It scared off the pigeons, and drank all my maté!

The funeral does not so much end as fade into the background, as the elderly veterans return to their bantering.

They share the same sense of perseverance, even now, that saw them through so many battles together.

At that moment, in the dense weeds, a pair of thick-treaded boots thud over the muddy soil, and a Revolver is cocked.

Soldier I: What now, Captain? We going over?

The shadows in the jungle tremble slightly, the soft whinny of a horse breaking their silence.

The captain looks back at his team and lowers his head.

???: There's no other choice ...

The elders prepare to leave, completely unaware that Nala has hidden herself.

Except for one.

Old Quitéria: You know, my dear, it's not polite to stuff yourself like that at a funeral.

Anjo Nala: ...?!

She wipes her mouth.

Old Quitéria: So, that's why the chickens were disappearing from the coop.

Anjo Nala: —No one else has noticed, have they?

Old Quitéria: Oh, of course not.

Anjo Nala: Then there's hardly a problem, is there? He-he!

Anjo Nala: —Ugh I've positively gorged myself, but I still feel so hungry ...

Anjo Nala: And a bit dizzy.

Old Quitéria: Oh dear, you don't look well. Have you gotten heatstroke?

Anjo Nala: Not sure ... *hic*

She shakes her head and sniffs the air.

Anjo Nala: Hmm, ah! It must be the mesquite trees. I always feel ill around them when they bloom. The smell makes me dizzy.

Old Quitéria: Well my dear, you've been doing so much to organize the funeral. Just don't push yourself too hard. Old Cinder would never forgive us if we didn't take good care of you.

Anjo Nala: Don't worry, Quitéria! I-I'm still strong!

Nala cheerfully flexes her arm as she straightens out her stance.

Just as the old woman is about to speak, a rustling breaks out from the nearby jungle, startling the long-tailed monkeys in the trees.

Not far away, the other elders walk in close step, beneath the cover of their umbrellas.

Anjo Nala: —!!!

Colonel: Who's there?!

Crowd: Be careful!

Elder I: Watch out! Someone's hiding over there!

Soldiers emerge from the jungle leading a few thin horses, their clothes are tattered, their faces exhausted. The leading officer raises both arms and moves forward.

Led by their old colonel, the veterans fall back into a battle-ready stance, all scanning the newcomers carefully.

???: Desculpa ... we didn't mean to intrude; we just need a place to rest. We haven't had a proper meal in a week. We can't go on much longer.

Elder I: Who are you? Why are you out here?

???: We're a patrol unit. We got lost in the jungle during a clearing mission.

This answer causes murmurs among the elders.

Elder I: You're Shorty's men, then?

Elder II: You got holes in your head? It's been ages since they took out Shorty. The military is in charge now.

Elder III: Don't trust a word out of the mouths of these leeches!

The elders grumble, but most shrink back, blinking at the unwelcome guests.

???: Wait, wait, please let me explain ...

The speaker takes a step forward, eyes darting over each elder's face.

His eyes widen, like a man discovering a hidden treasure.

???: I've hit the jackpot! Meu Deus! You're Colonel João Bastos!!

Colonel: ... ?!

The colonel lifts his eyebrows, his singular eye shifting wide open.

Colonel: Who's that?

???: The Rio Grande do Sul Uprising! General Protus's right-hand man? Could that really be the same face looking at me?

Colonel: The very same, but with one eye fewer.

???: *cough*

The other man respectfully salutes the colonel.

Moacir: Lieutenant Mondinho Moacir, Moacir of Bahia, Colonel.

Colonel: Bahia? Were you stationed by the Cachoeira River?

Moacir: Yes, Colonel.

Colonel: That's all wasteland now, isn't it?

Moacir: Yes, Colonel.

Colonel: Where the purslane grows wild and the brazilwood stacks higher than the piles of corpses that it took to claim that land.

Moacir: Colonel, you have no idea how many times I heard your name on my father's lips. You really taught those bullies a lesson.

Colonel: ...

Moacir: The papers said you still have that bullet in your head.

Colonel: It's all in the past now.

Moacir: Yes—so now my brothers and I are fighting for that honor too. Any violence and destruction you face here will be done away with!

The colonel's face changes.

Colonel: So, then you're the ones causing all the trouble around here?

Moacir: Trouble? No, Colonel, we're just following our orders. We're here to deal with what's left of the traitors and criminals.

Colonel: Don't give me that excuse. I know what your leaders are up to.

Colonel: Go back to the Capital and tell your commander that Bastos sends his regards. Tell him I don't approve of what they're doing.

Colonel: You're just feeding your youthful ambitions.

Moacir: Colonel, those are dangerous words.

Colonel: Come then, arrest me.

The colonel casts a stern and baleful glare at the young man.

Colonel: Although you may know me, boy, you and your men can't stay around here.

Moacir: Colonel ...

Moacir: We've been fighting for three months. Our rations are depleted. We have many injured.

Lieutenant Moacir rummages through his pockets, offering up a rain-soaked pack of cigarettes to Colonel Bastos.

The colonel remains motionless and unflinching.

Silent as a mountain.

Old Quitéria: I say—

The old caregiver breaks the silence, casting a frown at the colonel.

Old Quitéria: These boys have suffered enough. Is there any harm in bringing them inside for a little food and rest?

Old Quitéria: Look at the state of them. Most of them can't stand up straight; some of these injuries are near to turning gangrenous. Colonel, they'll never make it back to the capital like this!

Colonel: ... They ...

Old Quitéria: What about them?

Old Quitéria: Stop, whatever old friendships or grudges you have, all I see are injured boys in need of care.

Old Quitéria: If people need help, we help them. That's how we do things at the Heartfelt Home.

Elder I: She's right. We would be monsters to turn them away like this.

Elder II: But these aren't just ordinary people; we don't know their deal. Besides, we're struggling to keep all of us fed as it is!

Voices of support and opposition arise from the old veterans, until they've formed a deadlock.

Anjo Nala: Sir, I, um, I mean, Captain.

A soft voice, scarcely louder than a mosquito's buzz, chimes in.

Anjo Nala: Sorry to interrupt, but ... You should reconsider your offer. You won't move the colonel with those.

She moves in front of the colonel, pushing Moacir's cigarettes back with a weakly shaking hand.

Anjo Nala: The colonel only smokes one brand of cigarettes.

Anjo Nala: They're called "Green Papayas" ...

Moacir: ...?

Moacir: He frowns.

Moacir: You ...

Anjo Nala: What? Is there s-something?

Her heart suddenly tightens.

Anjo Nala: Ah ...! Ooh ...

There's noise, endless noise, then shouting, footsteps and panting, then the thrill of a predator in chase. A nightmare in her waking eyes.

Crowd: Oh, dear!

With everyone's exclamations, before Moacir could react, Nala sways a little and then collapses.

Elder I: She's fainted!!!

Elder II: Oh, dear. Someone check on her. The poor thing, it must be over-exhaustion!

Elder I: Could be, but then—she used to have panic attacks. It might be something similar.

Soldier I: Hold on, we might have a stretcher that can be of use ...

Moacir: Bring it over, quickly!

Moacir: Is this girl your caregiver?

Old Quitéria: Yes, and our very own little fool.

[English text unavailable]
COL-310002

Old Quitéria: Come on, let's all carry her back. You boys are welcome to rest at the Heartfelt Home for now!

Moacir: Vamos—

The troops give a small cheer, springing up like dried grass after a long-awaited rain.

The colonel grimaces, wheeling about and moving past Moacir wordlessly.

The misfit band of the wounded and the elderly trudge toward the house in the distant mist marked "Heartfelt Home."

Elder II: I'm not sure that letting this pack of wild half-grown puppies into the house is a proper choice. Hungry dogs bite.

Elder III: Ah, clam it up! Look at them. They're not so different to how we were back then.

Elder II: They don't even look like proper soldiers.

Elder I: Are you saying we did?

They trudge forward up the muddy hill, stopping to complain now and then, their rasping voices covered by birdsong.

[English text unavailable]
COL-310003

Parrots and Swamps

Nala's Bedroom

By noon the next day, her nightmare has passed.

The girl who fainted yesterday springs back into action.

Anjo Nala: Six a.m., go to the post office and collect the day's copy of The Morning Insight—check.

Anjo Nala: Seven a.m., breakfast; cornflakes, with fried bananas, sweet potatoes—check.

Anjo Nala: Next, uh, change the sheets. Oh, which side is the right side? What was it that Old Quitéria taught me?

Anjo Nala: All done for today. Ah, just one last thing.

She frowns and straightens her hair in the mirror.

Anjo Nala: Alright! Story time!

Tearoom, Heartfelt Home

Stories, yes, the most interesting ones can be heard in the tearoom. These always bring together both the elders and their eager young listener.

Elder I: When I first came to this place, not a single road was paved, and the dock? Forget it! We waded to shore. People didn't even know what a newspaper was!

Anjo Nala: Didn't you say last time that some people had already arrived looking to start a transport company?

She responds as she wipes the coffee cups with a handkerchief.

Elder II: Yes, right! I did, but they couldn't find anything to transport back then. How times have changed, eh? Now they're making record profits hauling cocoa and fruit!

Anjo Nala: Here's your maté. Careful, it's hot. Just think what might have happened if you invested, you'd have made a fortune—

Elder III: He's just sour over not buying that land when he had the chance. Next, he'll tell you he won it all in a brawl, but I happen to know the notary. He never owned a damn thing.

Anjo Nala: And this is yours—one cafézinho. It's lucky you have so many knowledgeable friends.

Elder III: Of course, back then, I wore Sete Léguas boots and drank Port wine. Everyone wanted to be friends with me.

Elder I: See, this is what I call nepotism. There's too much of it these days, Nala.

Elder I: We carved this place out of the jungle by sweat alone. Grew the cocoa trees by hand until they were tall and thick; we managed the climate and seasons well. That's the secret to our success.

Elder I: But now? All people talk about is "progress, progress." If you ask me, everything is moving too fast!

Anjo Nala: Alright, alright, calm down. Don't make me add an ao-ao egg to your caipirinha ...

Elder I: Hah—ha-ha-ha, oh, Nala—

The elder laughs heartily, taking the offered liquor.

As at the same time, there comes a sudden crash from another room.

Anjo Nala: Hm? There seems to be a lot of commotion over there!

Nala runs off to investigate, and the three elders watch her leave.

Elder II: Ei! My story's not finished yet.

Elder III: Where's she going?

But she didn't look back.

Elder III: ...

Elder I: Admit it, we couldn't get by without her.

The three elders exchange glances.

Elder III: That my coffee, then?

The elder passes the cup.

Elder II: And is that my maté?

The elder holding the maté tea hands it over to the one who was served liquor.

Elder III: And that's my liquor. Thank you very much.

They sigh contentedly as they at last receive their intended drinks.

Each takes a small sip.

Anjo Nala: Colonel! What's going on?

In one corner of the terrace, a macaw in a birdcage tilts its head, watching the odd scene—a scuffle between Colonel Bastos and a soldier.

Moacir: What's wrong?

Seeing Moacir approaching, Nala instinctively hides behind the colonel.

Soldier I: Sir, we were playing chess with Colonel Bastos, he, he couldn't pay up ...

Colonel: You little whelp, open your damned eyes and tell me what this is, if not money!

Soldier I: But Colonel, we don't use "conto" and "réis." This isn't money ... anymore.

Moacir: Shouldn't you be resting, soldier? Get moving—Vamos, corporal!

Soldier I: Yes, sir!

The colonel's gray mustache quivers slightly in the air.

Colonel: Nala, how much longer are these rascals staying?

Anjo Nala: Quitéria said they shouldn't leave this month. With the weather so hot and damp, it won't be good for their wounds.

Anjo Nala: But I can make them disappear if you like. All it takes is one simple trick.

Moacir steps forward.

Moacir: Sir.

Moacir: I'm deeply sorry that my men caused you trouble.

Moacir: Perhaps you might do me the honor of another game?

Colonel: ...?

Moacir: I'm sure the colonel would not begrudge a small wager.

Moacir: If I lose, we promise to leave within a week; if you lose ...

He looks over at Nala standing nearby.

Moacir: I'd like to taste the lady's cocktails—shall we say, a caipirinha?

The macaw ruffles its feathers while watching the little drama unfold.

Macaw: Quiet, quiet!

Colonel: Sure.

Colonel: Alright. But if you lose, you better keep your word and clear out in three days.

One game to determine whether these soldiers stay and rest at their leisure, or leave to face the dangerous trek home.

Elder I: Come and see, Old Bastos is playing chess against the captain.

Elder II: I bet a sagüi that our Old Bastos will destroy him.

Elder II: Shh, quiet.

It seems like the spectators are more nervous than the players.

Nala bites her collar, her gaze jumping between the two men.

Moacir: *cough*

Soldier II: The captain's wound is bleeding. I hope that won't affect his focus.

Elder I: Why did he decide on chess! Bastos never wins at chess! He's going to lose again, isn't he?

Anjo Nala: So, the colonel moves, then the captain. Then the colonel, then the captain.

Anjo Nala: It's really rather boring. I'm sure I have something else to do.

No one notices Nala slipping away from the crowd.

The spectators stand frozen with rapt attention, the silence only broken by the occasional flutter of the parrot's wings. The suspense ends with a simple phrase.

Colonel: Checkmate.

In 37 matches today, this was the colonel's only win.

All pause for a moment, but soon, the elders burst into cheers.

Elder I: Alright! Old Bastos, now they've learned, just because we're old, doesn't mean we don't know our stuff!

The colonel lifts his head, not a hair out of place.

Colonel: How about that, kid?

Colonel: Pick up your rifle, and let's part ways.

Moacir: ...

Moacir: What ...

Moacir: Haha, alright!

Soldier I: Bu-but, Captain—

Moacir: Let's go, boys, it seems we're not welcome here anymore.

The spectators shuffle away, the soldiers looking downcast with eyes watering at the prospect of their long march ahead.

Anjo Nala: Huh?

Nala runs out of the kitchen with a half-filled glass of liquor, a small trail of spills following behind her.

Anjo Nala: Is it over?

Elder I: That's right. Just before you got back! Old Bastos proved his chops once more.

Anjo Nala: Oh?!

Anjo Nala: You're leaving already? But I just made you a caipirinha.

Colonel: ...

Colonel: Nala?

The colonel looks at Nala from an old, incredulous eye. Nala tilts her head to the side in reply.

Moacir adjusts his military coat and approaches Nala with an officer's grace.

Moacir: Oh! Thank you, that's lovely—

Moacir: Miss.

Moacir takes the glass and drinks it in a single gulp.

Macaw: Quiet! Quiet!

Anjo Nala: ...

Moacir: Delicious. That cardamom, it's dreamlike ... it reminds me of my childhood.

Moacir: Thank you, Miss.

Anjo Nala: ...!

Moacir sets down the glass, turns, and prepares to leave.

Moacir: Alright, we've overstayed our welcome here. Move out!

Anjo Nala: ...

Colonel: ...

The colonel looks out over the gathered soldiers preparing to leave, his eye looking out past them and into a place distant in time and memory.

Colonel: *sigh* Wait.

His voice is hoarse and dry.

Colonel: Wipe up.

He hands Moacir a handkerchief.

Colonel: A few of your men are still feverish. The wiry-haired kid who threw those dice with me still has a crooked jaw.

Colonel: Your families wouldn't want to see you like this.

Elder I: Bastos?

Soldier I: Co-Colonel?

Anjo Nala: Colonel! Thank you!

Macaw: Quiet! Quiet!

Elder I: Letting those boys stay is a mistake.

Elder III: That's surprising. Hard to believe the old cyclops agreed to it.

The elders light their old quail pipes, as they look over the terrace.

Fiery bougainvillea twines around the window grilles, and below them laughing young soldiers.

Anjo Nala: No, wait, come on. Show me the medal. I want to see it.

Anjo Nala: I only mean that, I make bean porridge for everyone every day. Don't you think I deserve a little reward?

Anjo Nala: The Progress Club? Don't lie, they'll really throw a party for me?

Soldiers: Ha-ha-ha-ha, oh, Nala, Nala—

Anjo Nala: Why don't we go to the procession together? It'll be great fun!

Colonel Bastos sits under the mottled shadows by the limestone wall,

swatting flies with a fan made of parrot feathers.

Elder I: Your tea can's moldy. How long has it been since you made tea?

Elder II: I suppose I was just waiting for Nala to wash it out.

Elder III: But ... she's been busy.

...

Elder II: She's been—

Elder III: She's different from before.

Macaw: Quiet! Quiet!

...

Elder I: Does anyone know what that bird's actually saying?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310004

An Evening to Remember

A bullet is loaded.

"Bang—"

Shells clatter to the ground.

Another round is loaded.

"Bang—"

Ceramic bowls shatter, the rest rolling into the calabash on the ground.

Another round is loaded.

Old Quitéria: Oh!!! Damn it—!!! Nala!!!

Old Quitéria rushes into the basement.

Old Quitéria: Nala, what are you doing?!!

Anjo Nala: Quitéria! What happened? You look pale. The captain just showed me how to use this. I'm clearing out the aquaroaches in the garden.

Anjo Nala: See, more and more of them have been crawling out from cracks in the wall and floor tiles. Hey! Don't run—

Anjo Nala: "Babaca"! "Trouxa"! "Besta"!

Old Quitéria: Nala! Who taught you those words?

Chaos reigns in the basement as Nala chases the roaches.

Elder I: Ai, meu Deus! Who gave her that gun?

Elder II: A weapon like that is dangerous, child! Be careful!

The elders rush toward her as fast as their old bones can carry them.

Nala chases the roaches, and the elders chase Nala, from the basement to the tearoom, from the tearoom to the terrace.

"Bang—"

The source of the commotion, that black, damp creature, bursts with a short crack, leaving a puddle of methylene-blue ichor.

Anjo Nala: It's not actually that hard to use a gun! It's only taken me one day to learn!

Old Quitéria: Nala! Put the gun down!

Old Quitéria's voice echoes through the home.

Tearoom, Heartfelt Home

Elder I: Hello? Carla, did you hear? Old Cinder passed away two days ago—You heard? Okay, okay.

The hoarse voice echoes anxiously in the empty tearoom.

He hangs up, crosses out a name in the address book, and dials another number.

Elder II: When's lunch?

Elder III: Hold on. We'll heat up the leftover bean porridge in the fridge.

Elder II: But Nala said she'd make us grilled pork and fish today.

Elder III: Hmph. She probably just forgot.

...

Elder II: *sigh* I heard those young guys are taking her to the Progress Club down in the city. They said they even booked a fancy dinner with her at the Pearl Blue Hotel.

Elder III: Nala? Our Nala? Pfft—don't joke, does she even know how to dance?

Elder II: Hah! If she can dance, then I'm a swan.

Elder IV: But they like her.

...

Elder IV: I heard that they let her play with guns, teach her curses, now they're taking her on "adventures" to the city.

Elder III: Shoot. They're bad influences on her.

Elder II: Hahahahaha—you selfish old fart, you just don't want to eat old bean porridge every day.

Elder III: They've got too much already. The land, the people, the taxes, they publish the newspapers, these are their bridges and their trains. Everything is theirs!

Elder III: And us? We can't even get our pensions!

Elder IV: It'll come. We just have to wait a little longer.

Elder IV: They said there'd be news in December.

Elder III: December, that's what they say.

Elder III: But Old Cinder didn't make it to December.

...

Elder IV: Stop it, I think it's good for Nala to have some friends around her own age. They're getting ready for the procession together, that should be fun for her, right?

Elder III: Yes. The procession, is it that time of year again?

Elder II: Even if she really leaves us, perhaps it's for the better.

Elder II: It isn't like what it used to be out there. They have movie theaters, football arenas, so many things for young people to do.

Elder II: What do we have here?

...

Elder III: But we've got hot bean porridge. Nala can eat three bowls in one go.

...

Elder II: Sheesh, bean porridge.

Church of the Dragon-Slayer

Anjo Nala: I'm sure you'll love this procession! Every visitor, no matter how many new or unusual things they've seen, has absolutely fallen in love with it!

Anjo Nala: Every household in town will come out, and the streets will be filled with bananas, pumpkins, and sweet eggplants.

Anjo Nala: For a little money, you can buy all kinds of things; spices come cheap, there's cute printed cloth, and even bead necklaces.

Anjo Nala: Next, we'll raise the icon, and everyone will pray. I think most will pray for this rain to stop soon.

Anjo Nala: The colonel said if this rain keeps up, this year's harvest could be ruined.

Anjo Nala: So, we'll need to raise the icon high and tall, and decorate it with gold thread trim and beautiful embroidery.

Nala, holding a candle, leads Moacir through the chapel, showing off their recent work.

An enormous statue lies in the center of the chapel, awaiting decoration.

Moacir: You're amazing, Nala. Did you really make all this?

Anjo Nala: Naturally!

Nala twirls her hair, a little shy, looking away.

Moacir pulls out a bottle of perfume and offers it to her.

Anjo Nala: What's this?

Moacir: Perfume. It's for you, Miss.

Anjo Nala: Oh, perfume. Yes, I know it. My sister used to wear it. So did the colonel.

Anjo Nala: But I couldn't accept it. I'd never use it. Scents like these make me sneeze. Besides all that, I so love the smell of morning jasmine. How could I smell it if I was wearing this?

Nala gently pushes the perfume away.

Moacir: Sister? I never knew you had a sister.

There was a sharpness in his voice. It triggered something in her, a survival instinct.

Anjo Nala: ...

A nameless, brief silence.

Anjo Nala: My sister had a very kind heart. People just didn't know her very well.

She glances around, as if avoiding the topic.

Anjo Nala: What color ribbons should I pick? Red or blue? I prefer red.

Moacir: Your sister, is she about your age?

Moacir steps forward.

Her hands still.

Moacir: Are you still in touch?

Nala turns to face the questioning captain.

Anjo Nala: What? Why do you ask?

Nala steps back, and then once more.

Moacir: Oh, it's nothing—just curiosity.

Anjo Nala: I, I don't have a sister. I just made it up.

Anjo Nala: You know? Um, I've gotta go! I've chosen the ribbons. Oh! Right, Quitéria told me to make a special dish at the home tonight.

Moacir: Ei, wait! Don't go.

Nala turns sharply, her eyes scanning Moacir with wariness.

Moacir: What's wrong? Please, don't be scared. Nala, it's okay.

Her body tenses at his movement.

Moacir: It's okay. You're safe, Nala. I'm right here.

Moacir: You're safe here.

Seeing Nala still unresponsive, Moacir sighs.

Moacir: ...

Moacir: Termites.

Moacir: Did you know?

Moacir: A perfect termite mound needs to be above twenty degrees.

Moacir: I had a brother.

Moacir: When termites find the perfect soil for their nest, they feel it, examine it, then start digging.

Moacir: You might not know his name, but you'd have heard of his bank.

Moacir: They dig, dig, dig. They never stop.

Moacir: The transport companies here got their first loan from him. He made a fortune.

Moacir: He bought a house for my father, a real palatial thing, a villa on the beach, and that garden. But I didn't get to stay.

Anjo Nala: ...?

Until their kingdom is complete.

Nala scrutinizes Moacir from narrowed eyes.

He looks back, his face contorted with unspoken pain.

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: Are you still in touch with them?

Moacir: No. But I think I might visit him—my brother. When he's finally released.

Anjo Nala: He's in prison?

Moacir: Yes.

Anjo Nala: Is he a bad person?

Moacir: Yes.

Hesitation.

Anjo Nala: No, bad is ... maybe not the right word.

Anjo Nala: My sister wasn't bad either, even though—

Moacir: I know.

His voice quickens.

Moacir: I'm sure your sister isn't a bad person either.

Then, he deliberately slows down.

Moacir: I believe you.

Moacir stares at Nala.

Moacir: So, could I hear your sister's story now?

Until their kingdom is complete.

Anjo Nala: My sister ...

A gust of wind blows in from an open window, knocking over a candlestick on the table.

In a flash, the tablecloth has already caught fire.

Anjo Nala: Oh! Watch out!!

The flames spread quickly, climbing up the ribbons, snaking toward the fireworks in the corner.

Anjo Nala: Oh no!—Quick, put it out!

Anjo Nala: Oh no! Oh no! I've messed it all up again. Quitéria won't be able to cover for me this time.

Nala rushes over, trying to smother the flames as best she can.

She throws herself almost entirely into the flames, and soon enough they shrink under her.

Anjo Nala: Ouch! That was hot!

Moacir: ...

Moacir: You've already healed, that immense strength, those claws ...

He looks over her in the smoldering darkness.

Moacir: A shadow like a serpent's tail.

Nala stands up, swatting the soot off of her clothes.

Anjo Nala: ...!!!

The serpent-like shadow retreats down toward the girl.

The candlelight flickers, making the corner seem even darker.

Moacir tries to approach.

A pair of beast-like eyes appears from beyond the candlelight.

Anjo Nala: W-what did you see?

Moacir: ... ?!

As the light flickers back again, an even larger shadow emerges, this time with horns, claws, and a scent of blood.

There are legends that speak of this, of the people that disappear without a trace.

Their corpses picked apart by vultures and devoured by beasts until only their souls remain, left to wander in agony.

Moacir backs away in shaking steps.

Moacir: I ...

Moacir: Nala ...

Moacir: Miss, don't be afraid, please. I didn't see anything.

The shadow stretches closer, trembling slightly.

Moacir: You're an arcanist, aren't you?

Anjo Nala: ...

Moacir: It's okay. Don't be afraid. My brother was an arcanist too.

Moacir: It's nothing bad. Nothing unusual.

He suppresses the fear in his voice.

Moacir: I'm right here. I won't hurt you. I don't want to hurt you.

Moacir: You're safe here.

A familiar scent. Jasmine and gunpowder, fear and calm, uncertainty and reassurance, sincerity and delirium.

Moacir: Safe.

Moacir: No one will blame you for this; no one even has to know. They love you, Nala. Everyone that meets you feels that way. Everyone you meet.

Moacir: And I'm not someone who hates arcanists. I'm just a regular person.

Moacir: My brother was an arcanist too. I don't hate you. I'm not afraid. I believe in you.

Moacir: Just like I believe your sister is a good person. You see, in this, we are the same, we're no different.

Moacir: You shouldn't have to fear this world. We should be able to care for one another, to understand and to love each other.

Moacir: ...

The shadow stops its advance and then slowly begins to shrink, until the horns are gone and the claws retract, leaving only the girl.

Moacir: It's okay. You are safe, Nala. See, I believed in you, and you, you can believe in me.

...

The air is hot, still, and calm.

Moacir: I will never speak a word of this, Nala.

...

Anjo Nala: I—

Anjo Nala: Is that true then?

She looks into Moacir's eyes, searching for sincerity.

Moacir: Of course.

We should be able to care for one another, to understand and to love each other.

Her face is vacant for a moment, then she nods.

Anjo Nala: I trust you.

She blinks.

As she steps outside the chapel, she spies something on the ground—a long-extinguished Green Papayas cigarette.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310005

A Star Fallen

Dear Mr. President,

Please accept our deepest greetings and well-wishes.

I hope you can look past the nasty nicknames we gave you. I am still your most loyal servant.

Old Quitéria: Nala has some business today, so I'll be leading the poetry reading.

A stir runs through the gathered elders.

Elder I: Where's Nala?

Elder II: Yeah, it won't be the same without her! She loves reading poetry, and we love listening to her. Why wouldn't she be here?

Old Quitéria: Quiet down, everyone, quiet down.

Elder II: Is she still out with those soldiers? Did she ditch us to go to the club?

Old Quitéria: No! Of course not! It's nothing like that!

Old Quitéria: Now come on, let's get back to the reading.

Old Quitéria: "Inhabiting this pitiful land, dwelling among beasts."

Old Quitéria starts the poetry to stop the chatter, and the elders have no choice but to follow along.

"Pitiful man and pitiful beast, together dwelling in this ravine of life.

Sorrowful freedom binds you, mutating you into a beast."

"Friend, oh friend, kisses and caresses, when did their faces change?

Family, oh family, the warm bonfire turns into a man-eating demon."

...

But before long, the whispers return.

Elder I: I heard Nala might leave us for good.

Elder II: No way, where did you hear that?!

Old Quitéria: Ahem! What is it that has got you whispering this time?

Elder I: They, they said—

Old Quitéria: What did they say?

The elder darts his eyes around the room and clears his throat.

Elder I: They say Nala's leaving us.

The room roars into loud debate.

Old Quitéria: Who said that?

Elder I: The soldiers, they said the captain and Nala have been out together a lot.

Elder I: Now they're saying Captain Moacir's offered Nala a new job—something in the capital with him, a government desk job, or maybe working for the newspaper.

Elder II: No matter what, Nala is leaving. She's starting a new life.

The clock chimes three times, and the room goes silent.

Old Quitéria: Nonsense.

Old Quitéria sets down the poetry book and summons up her strength to straighten out her back.

Her real name is Gintalia, but she prefers to go by Quitéria.

Old Quitéria: Everyone, listen.

Her voice is strong.

In the past 65 years, she'd delivered 267 babies with her own two hands.

Old Quitéria: Twenty years ago, I found her in a run-down corner of this city. I'll care for her as long as I still draw breath.

...

Old Quitéria: I know that all of you feel the same way.

It was her hands, her scent, and her voice that welcomed each one of those children into the world.

Anjo Nala: ♪♫♪ Hmm hmm hmm hmm ... ♪♫♪

There is a knock on the door.

Anjo Nala: Quitéria! There you are! I found some star anise; maybe I can add a little to the seasoning. What do you think?

Old Quitéria: Have you prepared your things?

Anjo Nala: We're still in need of a cover! I had been thinking of sewing our old socks together. They're durable enough, and we can use them as a tablecloth after.

Old Quitéria looks at Nala with staring eyes.

Old Quitéria: I don't mean for the procession.

Old Quitéria: I mean your own things.

Anjo Nala: Me? I promise I haven't snuck any food away this time. Not even a single piece of chocolate is out of place!

Old Quitéria simply joins her and begins helping her organize.

Old Quitéria: You know, toothbrushes need to be replaced every three months, and if you go dancing, please dress modestly, and you must remember to always say please and thank you, and as much as you love it, don't give people nicknames!

Old Quitéria: Most importantly, don't be too quick to trust others.

Anjo Nala: Why are you saying this?

Quitéria doesn't respond. She just opens the drawer and helps her pick out clothes.

Anjo Nala: He-he, you're like the Pachamama from my dreams right now.

Old Quitéria: If you aren't careful, people lead you astray.

Anjo Nala: Oh, stop. I'm not some old fool like Flayer. Why are you treating me like I'm clueless?

Old Quitéria pinches her nose, takes a deep breath, and looks up into her eyes.

Anjo Nala: ...?

Anjo Nala: Quitéria?

Old Quitéria: Remember that story I told you? About the sun god who ended the great flood, causing the first rainbow to appear in the sky?

Old Quitéria: You never know if something beautiful brings a blessing or a curse. A rainbow to some is salvation, but others see it as an omen of death.

Old Quitéria: You know I ... I used to make a living interpreting dreams. They'd pay, and I'd divine.

Old Quitéria: But each time I looked into the future, I saw things I hoped would never occur. I hoped those omens were just shadows.

Old Quitéria: Still, every outcome can be beautiful in its own right.

Nala is stunned, unable to digest the information.

Old Quitéria: Maybe it really is a new world, a world full of potential for young people, for you.

Old Quitéria pats Nala's head.

Old Quitéria: I'll always be proud of you.

If it rains for another week, the colonel's wheelchair will rust over so badly it'll be just another chair.

The colonel knows this better than anyone, nervously shaking his legs and rolling back and forth in the Heartfelt Home's courtyard.

He holds a thick bundle of letters wrapped in rose-colored paper.

He can't roll this rusty wheelchair all the way to the post office alone.

But soon, his dilemma is interrupted by the sound of sobbing.

Colonel: They say if you cry during the rainy season, the rains will never end.

Anjo Nala: Colonel?! Oh, you're here.

Colonel: I—*cough*

Anjo Nala: ...?

Colonel: I-I could hear you crying. You almost sounded like the mosquitoes in the Amazon, you know.

Anjo Nala: I wasn't crying.

Nala sniffs.

Anjo Nala: I just felt sad, like the rain, like this never-ending rain.

Colonel: Sad, an angel like you? Don't tell me playing sad is a new fad with you young folks?

Anjo Nala: No, it's only Old Quitéria came to me and told me some things. I don't quite understand what she meant by it, but now somehow, I just feel so sad.

Colonel: Oh! Oh! Alright, alright!

The colonel panics, looking at Nala's head, wanting to pat it but instead humming a tune.

Colonel: "A real soldier never wastes a word, is as brave as an eagle, and as strong as a tiger ..."

A song from a bygone era of war, written by a one-eyed poet.

Anjo Nala: *hum* Ahchoo!

Colonel: See? Sneeze it out, and the sadness goes away.

Nala sniffs and shakes her head. As she raises her eyes, she notices what the colonel is clutching behind his back.

Anjo Nala: ...?

Anjo Nala: What's this, Colonel?

Colonel: This, this is ... Never mind. Don't look!

Anjo Nala: "Thank you for taking the time to read this."

Anjo Nala: "This letter is once again to inquire about the pension distribution."

Anjo Nala: "The fact is, I submitted our application twenty-five years ago and received confirmation ten years ago."

Anjo Nala: "I do not have high expectations for the amount; my years of waiting and perseverance were for something more valuable than a number."

Anjo Nala: "I just can't stand these day-to-day struggles. Even though I now live in a welfare home, and life here is quite comfortable."

Anjo Nala: Mm-hmm.

Anjo Nala: "But recently, a group of people, acting like bandits, have been brutally seizing our land."

Anjo Nala: Mm-hmm.

Anjo Nala: Is that, did you mention me here?

Anjo Nala: Huh? "Take her away?"

Nala looks up at the colonel, then back at the letter.

Anjo Nala: ...?

Anjo Nala: Was I ... leaving?

Colonel: Deus me livre ...

The colonel seems flustered and uneasy.

Colonel: Damn it.

He rocks uncomfortably back and forth in his wheelchair.

Colonel: Just toss it in the fire.

He seizes on an impulsive decision.

Colonel: Look at this. It's all broken sentences, incoherent grammar, and so many typos. This isn't my writing. You know that, Nala.

Colonel: So, help me burn it.

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: Of course, of course.

She understands his meaning. It comes to her as clearly as the sounds of night.

Anjo Nala: You were a member of the Literary Society, and there are so many errors. Yes, this couldn't be your writing.

Colonel: Ha ... ha-ha!

The colonel snatches the letter back.

Colonel: Oh, damn.

He looks back to the entrance of the Heartfelt Home. It seems so far and distant now.

He meekly returns the letter to Nala.

Colonel: Just burn it.

Nala holds her gaze on the colonel,

with those aconite purple eyes shining in the moonlight.

On the terrace at night, between two pillars, a wire holds up the elders' uniform white cotton shirts.

The embers vanish beneath the puffs of smoke rising from the roasting corn stalks.

They watch the letter burn to ash, its edges curling in the fire.

Anjo Nala: What do you think Old Cinder is doing now?

Anjo Nala: Do you think he's watching us?

Colonel: He's probably busy writing complaints to Heaven's representatives.

All that is left of the paper is ash scattered over the ground.

Anjo Nala: ...

Nala stares intently at the ashes.

Anjo Nala: I'm not leaving, Colonel.

The colonel's mustache twitches.

Colonel: That's your decision to make, not mine.

He struggles to squeeze out the words.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310006

Sleeptalking

Church of the Dragon-Slayer

It is midnight, and Captain Moacir is preparing to go out when he sees the colonel sitting in the chapel, cleaning his gun.

Colonel: This rifle fought by my side from Rio Grande do Sul to São Paulo. It's almost my third arm.

Colonel: A G43 semi-automatic rifle, Shorty used it once. He said it was quite handy.

Colonel: A Springfield rifle, with magnified sight.

Colonel: MAS-36 carbine, the last one, seized from our prisoners of war.

Colonel: And finally, a .357 Magnum revolver, just like the one in your hand.

He seems to have anticipated Moacir's arrival.

Moacir: They're well maintained.

Colonel: Yes, but they're all empty.

Moacir: No matter, at least they're good for show.

...

Colonel: I heard you're leaving after the procession tomorrow.

Moacir: Yes, our wounded have recovered well, thanks to your nurses here.

Moacir: Knowing that you're living well under their care gives me peace of mind.

Moacir: This is a country growing stronger by the day. I hope one day soon, we will be able to ensure the welfare of all our elders like you.

Colonel: Hmph.

He lets out a sneer.

Moacir: Did I say something wrong?

Colonel: No. My nose itches.

Moacir: Alright, alright.

Moacir: Then I should go check on the horses in the stable. After all this rest, they might need a new shoeing, and we're hitting the road in a couple of days.

Moacir takes two steps out, then the colonel speaks again.

Colonel: I know that bay horse.

Colonel: And I knew its owner. It wasn't you.

Moacir: Oh, oh, yes, Colonel, you have sharp eyes.

Colonel: I happen to know its former owner, and his fate was not ideal.

Moacir: Well, I suppose that depends on your definition.

The colonel doesn't respond. It dawns on Moacir that he hasn't looked at him once through their conversation.

He just stares at the barrel, unflinching.

Moacir waits a while, then, realizing the colonel has nothing more to say, turns back.

But he stops again after two steps.

Moacir: You know, you're very much like my father.

Colonel: Heh, then I apologize.

Moacir: He always preferred riding horses, even as the cars took over the roads. "A horse is an extension of a man's spirit," he said.

Colonel: Well said.

Moacir: He died on horseback in the end.

...

Moacir: Sir, pardon my boldness, but may I ask, do you have children?

Colonel: A son, yes.

Moacir: Well, then perhaps I could recommend him for a position in the government. If he's willing to learn and works hard, he could get a post in no time.

Colonel: He died.

Moacir: ...?

Moacir: I'm sorry.

The colonel uncomfortably moves his jaw, trying to adjust it.

Colonel: That day, his mother told him to go find work, but instead, he went to the San Sebastian Square to watch the cockfighting.

Colonel: That day, there was some chaos in the square, a fight—a bloody fight.

Colonel: He was shot dead.

Colonel: To this day, I still don't know what happened. Now, I can't even remember the last thing he said to me.

Colonel: A bullet, it may have different calibers, different materials, but none of them carry their owner's name on it. Do they?

Colonel: It's strange, isn't it? That after living a life of war, it is my son that dies in peace.

Colonel: In everything, there should be cause and effect. A reason, but so often it seems things happen for no reason at all. We see the effect but cannot find the cause.

Moacir: I suppose so, but you are a man of war, Colonel. You must have learned that harsh lesson long ago.

Colonel: Of course. He was a foolish young boy. He got what he deserved.

Moacir: There's no need to say that.

Moacir: But I must disagree. Everyone dies for a reason.

Colonel: Including the people you've executed?

Moacir: Yes.

Moacir: I know every one of their crimes and exactly which level of hell they're destined for.

Colonel: Their crimes paved the way for your future.

...

Moacir: Sir.

Moacir's tone turns harsh.

Moacir: I still don't understand where your hostility comes from.

The colonel chuckles softly.

Colonel: Stellina.

Colonel: You've been around long enough; you should know what life is like here.

Colonel: For the old, it is all gossip and griping. We watch the cocoa grow, whiling away our twilight years with trivialities.

Colonel: But when it comes to a young man, it's different.

Colonel: They should've gotten their diploma, had a good career, and made this city more prosperous than the most luscious cacao tree.

Colonel: Instead, boys find themselves embroiled in brawls over honor and retribution, chasing dreams of titles and glory. It's the same stupid games they play everywhere. Politics and machismo.

The colonel pauses, looking up at Moacir.

Colonel: You tell others you have a brother, but what you don't mention is that you put him in prison yourself.

Moacir: Tsk.

Moacir: Colonel, eavesdropping is beneath a man like you.

The colonel doesn't reply.

Faces he hasn't thought of for years float before him, the line between life and death blurs.

Colonel: You may think you've got a winning hand,

Colonel: but there'll come a day when you realize it can't protect you from true danger.

Moacir: See, Colonel, that's where you and I differ. I don't play the game.

Moacir: I set the table.

Moacir: Whoever sets the rules controls the outcome.

Moacir: When Pedro II decided to stay, when he received the reply, "The apple is ripe," when he gave the "Cry of Ipiranga"—

Moacir: He won not with a sword but with a crown.

Moacir: In fact, Colonel, we've never been part of a true revolution. We only passed through one skirmish after another.

Moacir: Only fools believe in seizing power. No, when you know the game, power finds you.

Moacir: Control the cause, and you control the effect.

Moacir: See? This is how we differ.

Captain Moacir loads two bullets into the colonel's rifle.

He pulls the trigger.

The weapon is clearly well preserved and finely maintained.

But as the hammer falls, and the bullet stays inert in the chamber.

Moacir: What a shame—your rifle is broken, Colonel.

Time, a vast, solemn, stirring graveyard.

Having walked this graveyard for half a century, the old man finally lets out a silent sigh.

Colonel: We've conquered the wilderness of this land, yet somehow, we failed to coexist with civilization.

Bastos turns and steps into the silent darkness.

First, he raises one hand and waves behind him.

Then, he lifts both hands above his head.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310007

Fall of the Fortress

Town Street

The first rays of dawn break through the clouds, signaling the day of the procession, and some hope, the end of the rainy season.

Old Quitéria: You say Old Jorge's clothes don't fit? This is the only set we have. He'll have to wear what he's got.

Old Quitéria: Everyone must have a candle. Place it firmly in the holder, and don't let the rain put it out.

Old Quitéria: Don't drink so much. They'll be plenty after the procession.

The drunkard's cup is spilled over with intent, as Old Quitéria moves among the elders.

Outside the Heartfelt Home, a chaotic scene is forming at the entrance, with men hoisting the statue, people holding candle stands, elders and estate owners putting on their robes.

The colonel's mustache is perfectly still today, even a tornado would fail to ruffle a hair on it.

Colonel: When does the procession end?

Old Quitéria: Good heavens, you're thinking of the end before it's even begun. Saints above, I hope they'll forgive you for this irreverence!

Colonel: Fine, fine, and if I'm good and devout, will I get an extra piece of cornmeal cake for lunch?

Old Quitéria: If you don't cause trouble, you can have as much as you want.

The colonel sinks back into his wheelchair contented, glancing sideways at the nearby soldiers.

Soldier I: You know, you're the most beautiful girl I've ever laid eyes on. Please, might I take your hand?

Vendor: Oh dear, but please don't say that! My hands are covered in fish guts!

Soldier I: Even so, they are still the gentlest I have ever held.

Colonel: Tsk.

The colonel sneers, looking for someone.

Moacir stands in the corner, amused by the scene unfolding.

Colonel: What's that bastard hiding in his coat?

He squints, and then abruptly starts wheeling back to the chapel.

Old Quitéria: What are you doing, Bastos?

Old Quitéria blocks his path.

Colonel: None of your damn business.

Old Quitéria: The procession is exactly my business, Colonel. Now please, get back into line.

Anjo Nala: Colonel! Ah—Watch out!

Nala rushes out from the home, carrying her microphone, tripping up into a tangled mess of cables.

Quitéria steadies her.

Old Quitéria: Don't worry too much, dear. I know today is your first time leading the procession.

Old Quitéria untangles the wires and hands the microphone back to her.

Anjo Nala: Oh! Me, worry? Over this trifling thing. I'm hardly nervous at all!

Old Quitéria: Haha, that's good.

Anjo Nala: Well, just a tad worried. There are some sentences in the speech you wrote down that I don't know that I understand, and I still have yet to memorize everything perfectly.

Old Quitéria: No problem. I'll hold the script for you. Just watch my lips. I'll say a line, you repeat it.

Anjo Nala: Great!

Old Quitéria: Ei! Who brought these geese here? How's the procession supposed to move?

The neighbor driving the geese shoos them, but the gray-and-white geese seem to have their own plans.

Poultry Farmer: They're acting real strange. They won't listen at all!

He shouts at Old Quitéria, who waves him off, signaling him to handle it.

Golden ornaments, towering statues, red robes, purple headpieces, blue macaws, and the mingling scents of meat and osmanthus fill the air.

Everyone around has been utterly absorbed by the pageantry.

Nala walks through the crowd, crouches down, and picks up a white goose.

Anjo Nala: Shh, it's okay, it's okay. Be a good goose, and come with me.

She holds the white goose, and the other geese obediently line up behind her.

The clock strikes the hour, and everyone turns to look at the distant bell tower commemorating Saint George, the Dragon Slayer.

The procession begins.

Elder I: I've never seen such a spectacle. The last time there were this many people was five years ago at the cockfight!

Elder II: That shows how many people want the rain to stop. Everyone's praying with all their strength.

Elder I: Let us pray that the saints above see our work here, and bless us.

The procession moves from the home toward the square, with more and more people joining in, holding candles.

Nala leads the line of white geese at the front, humming softly.

Anjo Nala: *At the same crossroad*

Anjo Nala: *When the warm days grow cold*

Anjo Nala: *Leaves are falling down*

Anjo Nala: *To the ground*

People in the procession begin singing along quietly.

Anjo Nala: *Fire can't burn down*

Anjo Nala: *My past into ashes*

Anjo Nala: *By now*

More and more join in, their voices growing louder.

The procession reaches San Sebastian Square, where the grand statue lies.

A beam of light shines on the statue, and Nala stands before it.

Old Quitéria waves from the crowd, mouthing the words to her.

Old Quitéria: Watch my lips, follow along.

Nala nods, watching Old Quitéria's lips.

A strange thought strikes her—suddenly she realizes she has never seen snow.

...

Anjo Nala: Hello? Ahem, everyone, hello.

The microphone squeals, and the crowd murmurs.

Anjo Nala: Hello, can you hear me?

Elder I: Yes!

Anjo Nala: Heh-heh, sorry, I've not spoken in front of this many people before.

Elder II: It's okay, Nala!

Elder III: You can do it, Nala! Just say anything!

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: Then, shall I begin?

Old Quitéria: Go on.

Her voice is slow and steady. Nala looks at her, who returns her glance.

She nods, clearing her throat.

Quitéria's lips move, and Nala speaks.

Anjo Nala: I think we can all agree that this isn't the best time in our lives.

Anjo Nala: We haven't seen a single cocoa leaf standing tall, no datura flower blooming, and the sunlight never lingers longer than a day.

Anjo Nala: Only rain, endless rain.

Anjo Nala: Rain like this always reminds me of my childhood.

Anjo Nala: Gentle yet suffocating breaths in the cradle, flat feet stomping on nettles, all those poetic and joyous synonyms.

Anjo Nala: Speaking of childhood?

She smiles to herself.

Anjo Nala: Did we really have the wonderful childhood we imagined?

Anjo Nala: Things always seem more beautiful and grander when they're viewed from a distance.

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: It seems this yearning comes with the very realization that we may never return to those happier times.

Anjo Nala: Here we are, in this place we've always called home. It's where we grew up, and it's where we'll grow old.

Anjo Nala: But isn't it strange? Why should we feel longing for the land we've grown on? Why should it feel foreign to us?

Anjo Nala: Why would we all feel this way?

The warm sunlight makes her head spin.

When she comes back to her senses, the crowd is silent, looking at her with strange expressions. Some bow their heads quietly.

Nala's palms are sweaty, and she wipes them secretly on her sides.

Anjo Nala: I'm so sorry.

The microphone screeches again.

Anjo Nala: *deep breath*

Everyone looks at Nala, some trying to comfort her with their eyes.

Anjo Nala: I've tried so hard to prepare these words, but still, I can't quite memorize them.

Old Quitéria freezes.

Anjo Nala: Thank you, Quitéria, but you needn't prompt me anymore. There is something I should like to say from my heart.

Old Quitéria lowers the script in her hand, as stunned as everyone else.

Anjo Nala: Ahem, ahem—!

Another screech.

Anjo Nala: This, this is your home. And it's mine, too.

The simplicity of her words doesn't seem to have the desired effect.

Another bead of sweat slides down her face.

Anjo Nala: Leave-leaving home might seem easy, but one never truly breaks away from their hometown.

Anjo Nala: And I'm fortunate. I've never left, and I never will.

Her voice trembles, but she presses on.

Anjo Nala: I will never leave you. I don't want to, and I won't—I will never leave the Heartfelt Home.

The crowd goes from rustling to silence.

Anjo Nala: Because, just like you,

Anjo Nala: I love everything here.

Anjo Nala: I love our little parrot that babbles nonsense on the terrace, I love Camilo's cheap snake wine, I love Quitéria's almond cakes and Old Jorge's tunes on the piano.

Anjo Nala: The bright red roses and fragrant lilacs, the toucan's call, and this golden land of cocoa trees at sunrise—

She's said too much at once, and gasps for another breath.

Anjo Nala: And-and the never-ending rain, and you.

Anjo Nala: I love you all.

The crowd is quiet, every elder's eyes fixed on Nala.

Anjo Nala: I love everyone here.

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: ...

Dead silence.

Anjo Nala: I-I really don't know what else to say. In fact, no words could properly express my deep love for this land.

Anjo Nala: Only singing, yes! Only a song without end.

She pauses.

Anjo Nala: So, let's sing! Let's all sing!

Anjo Nala: Sing together, and keep on singing.

Anjo Nala: Even under the shadow of war, we will keep on singing, till the day the sun shines upon us again.

The crowd roars up to join her, their voices mixing with the intense scent of almond blossoms filling the air. They feel dizzy, joyful, confused, angry.

Elder I: Oh, dear, did you hear that? Nala said she won't leave!

Elder II: Yes, we don't have to worry about losing her. Oh, what was I thinking? Of course, she wouldn't leave us.

Crowd: Nala! Nala—!!

Crowd: We love you—!!

Crowd: We love you—!!!

Crowd: You're a saint, an angel, oh, Nala—!!!

Crowd: Nala, Nala, Nala ...

Crowd: Anjo Nala, Anjo Nala, Anjo Nala, Anjo Nala!!!

Everyone, the elders, food vendors, idle gamblers, estate owners and their workers, the children of the choir.

Everyone is lost in this revelry, and at the apex of it stands the angel bathed in sunlight,

holding a white goose, looking at the world.

Moacir: Then it's true. She is exactly who I suspected.

Moacir: That seductive power in her voice, making those who love her adore her like a goddess.

Moacir: A succubus.

Moacir: Thank heaven, finally my wait is rewarded.

Moacir: It seems this place truly is a blessed land.

He is in tears.

The flames fade away as she falls back, plunging into darkness.

Lights, parties, graceful figures, chewing gum; gunfire, bullet casings, rats in the sewers; chanting, the scent of breakfast, ash in the ashtray.

Coughing, newspapers, the universe, a toucan in a dream, day after day of rumbling thunder and drizzle.

And an unexpected question.

Anjo Nala: ...

Anjo Nala: Sister?

Anjo Nala: Why?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310008

Blood-Soaked Earth

All smiles freeze.

From that second on, the world begins to rewind, rewind infinitely, back to its very inception, its first breath.

Anjo Nala's lifeless pupils reflect all the dead souls buried in San Jeronimo Cemetery throughout history.

And in the next moment, time snaps back.

She vanishes from where she stands, as if she had only been a rumor.

Everyone sees a toy fall to the ground.

She lies there absurdly, comically, grotesquely.

A shadow suddenly darts by, snatching the toy from in front of their eyes, before disappearing into the crowd.

Crowd: Nala!!!

Crowd: Where did she go?!

Crowd: What just happened?!

Crowd: What the hell?!

Crowd: It was a shooting!!! I heard the gunshot!

The furious crowd is unable to contain their rage. They rush toward the nearby soldiers.

Crowd: What are you doing!!!

The soldiers in the crowd shoulder their rifles in unison.

Soldier I: Stop there! Stand down!

Soldier II: Anyone moves, I'll blow their brains out!!!

No one dares, even the flames on the candles seem to hold still.

Soldier II: You are all guilty of harboring a fugitive.

Soldier II: But as you allowed us to rest and heal in your quaint little town, the captain has decided to show you mercy.

The soldiers, holding their guns, fall back toward a singular point. Their escape route taking them toward the palm grove beyond the square.

Colonel: Oi, kid.

The colonel's voice is hoarse as he rolls out from the crowd in his wheelchair.

Colonel: Put down that gun, or shoot me.

There is a menace in the words that shocks the soldiers, who back away cautiously, whispering among themselves.

Soldier I: What's wrong? Does he have a gun?

Soldier II: No way, he couldn't have a gun.

Soldier I: Then why is he ...?

The soldiers keep their eyes fixed on the colonel.

Soldier I: Hand over your gun, or everyone here dies.

Colonel: I'm not carrying a damned gun.

Soldier I: Then raise your hands and go back.

Colonel: Why?

Soldier I: Why? Because I DO have a gun.

Colonel: So what?

The young soldier has no answer for the veteran. He begins to sweat, fumbling over the trigger.

He takes aim.

Soldier I: Old man, I didn't want it to come to this.

Colonel: Go on, pull the trigger.

Colonel: Or else I'll—

The colonel suddenly reaches into his coat, as if to pull something out.

"Bang—" The bullet fires, but the soldier's gun is yanked upward, pointing straight to the sky.

Old Quitéria, using the strength that has delivered 267 babies, strikes quickly from behind, wrenching the soldier's gun upward.

The shot startles the birds in the nearby grove, and a flock of toucans bursts out, cutting over the sunset sky.

It is a signal—at once villagers, elders, and soldiers all fall into chaotic violence.

The Elders: You heartless bastards, I'll gut every last one of you!!!

The Elders: I will @#$%^& !!!

Vulgar and unrepeatable curses fill the air as bowls spill and the sounds of gunfire, smashing pottery, and screams erupt together.

The elders swing canes, pots, pans, and even their own wheelchairs, striking with aged precision at their heads; Old Quitéria pants as she chokes a soldier from behind with her ruffles of her apron.

They haven't fought in years, but now they will fight as if it was their last stand.

The sky is red as if an arrow had pierced the sun. Below, people flee the scene in a panic.

Colonel: You sons of b*****s.

The one-eyed Colonel João Bastos grabs an iron pot, maneuvering his rusty wheelchair with astonishing speed as he catches up with a soldier retreating into the palms and smashes his head in.

Then he charges deeper into the grove.

Moacir: I never intended for things to escalate like this.

Soldier III: Shoot! Those old folks just went nuts.

Moacir: They're not crazy; don't underestimate them.

Colonel: —?!

The colonel's single eye catches a familiar sight.

Colonel: Hey!!!

Soldier III: It's the colonel. He's coming after us!

Moacir stands still, giving no reaction to the soldier.

Soldier III: Captain?

Moacir: You men go ahead. Go on. I'll handle this. Vamos.

He waves the wind-up toy in his hand and walks toward the colonel.

Moacir: She wasn't just a caregiver, Colonel.

He seems pleased with the colonel's expression.

Moacir: She's a demon.

Meanwhile, just beyond the grove, the square is filled with screams.

Soldier I: Ahhhhh!!!

Old Quitéria swings her cane at a soldier, one she had only just patched up, hammering down on his bandaged leg.

bang

Moacir: Mata Hari's sister, Nala Hari.

Old Quitéria: No mercy! You hear me? I will break you just the same as I healed you.

Old Jorge grabs a soldier by the hair, dragging him to the fountain. Under the gaze of the Dragon Slayer, he holds his head underwater until he stops struggling.

Moacir: With the battle going on between the government and the Foundation, her bounty will be worth more than every last bean of cocoa in this entire country.

Old Quitéria: *cough* Phew!

Soldier I: *pant*

Soldier II: Damn, these old bastards, they're so strong.

Old Quitéria: Hah, bleh!

San Sebastian Square is covered in spatters and pools of blood as thick as a heavy rain.

The bodies of elders and soldiers lie scattered on both sides, facing up to the dimming sky.

Her furious roar echoes in the sky, causing Moacir to pause.

Moacir: At first, I wasn't sure. She looked familiar. I'd seen that wanted poster—yes, who hadn't seen it? Such a beautiful face seemed almost like a fantasy.

Moacir: But I made sure, sure that she was the girl on the wanted poster.

Moacir glances back at it all, as if the blood-red square has nothing to do with him.

Moacir: Do you know how I felt when I found her?

Moacir: Astonished, utterly astonished. It has been twenty-five years, and she looks as if she hasn't aged a day.

Moacir: Yet she was as foolish and as evil as ever. There was a difference though, something broken inside her. She'd do anything to feel valued, she'd let anyone use her.

Moacir: But once I learned her true identity, she became wary of me. Her vigilance kept me at a distance.

Moacir: This mess wasn't my intention. You see, but it was beyond my control.

The colonel looks at the man, wishing now he had brought his cigarettes with him.

Colonel: So you aren't a government soldier. You're just a hitman.

Moacir: Yes and no.

The colonel could feel his age, his breath was thin.

Colonel: This won't make your father and brother proud.

Moacir: Who cares?

Moacir: He's dead. They're both dead.

Moacir: They paid for their mistakes.

Colonel: *cough* Hahahahaha!

The colonel coughs twice, then bursts into laughter.

Moacir: Hahahahaha!

The captain-turned-hitman returns the laughter.

Moacir: Now, let's call a truce, what do you say?

Moacir: I'll take my billions and leave, while you can continue living peacefully in your little welfare home.

Moacir: We go on as if nothing has happened, you and all your friends can go back to living as you had before.

Moacir: It's like a marvelous story full of conflict, violence, and blood, but in the end, the audience sees that it's about love and peace. How grand.

Moacir: Think of it as a way to have a second son. I'll look after you, old man, I promise.

Moacir: As for me. I suppose I've always wanted a chance to make peace with my father.

Moacir: Goddamn, I'm a great storyteller, aren't I?

A yellow butterfly, from who knows where, gently lands on the colonel's shoulder.

The colonel smiles, feeling as if a great weight has been lifted from him, light as air.

Colonel: We're the children of our homeland. And in its embrace, we've shed blood, sweat, and tears.

Colonel: We are betrayed by it, exploited by it, furious at it till our deaths.

Colonel: But we embrace it, love it, treasuring it with bitter tears. We help it, change it, build it with their own hands. Only we can endure the tears and loneliness of this land.

Colonel: Guided by the stars, they paddle their canoes, drinking the sap of the rubber tree. In every quiet night, they are one with it.

Colonel: I didn't understand why you didn't get it before. Now I do.

Colonel: You'll never be one of us.

Moacir trembles.

Colonel: Perhaps you're right. It is a good story.

Colonel: But it doesn't end well for you—you worthless dog.

The colonel pulls out a revolver from his coat, one he'd so long been reluctant to use. But now—

—now he loathes it.

But the captain's young reflexes move faster, firing a shotgun blast into the colonel's abdomen.

The crack of gunfire sends the birds and butterflies in town careening into the air, but as the moment calms, so too does the rain.

Colonel: Uh!

Moacir: ...

Moacir: A worthless dog? Hah.

Moacir: Was that really the best an esteemed member of the literary society could manage?

Colonel: Heh heh.

Colonel: I couldn't be bothered ...

Moacir: What?

The colonel's voice is so faint that he instinctively moves closer to listen.

Colonel: At my age ... why waste time ... choosing words!

The colonel suddenly lunges, biting his ear and tearing it off in a moment of savage aggression.

Moacir: Aahhhh—!!!

Moacir: You ****! I'll **** your whole family!!!

He raises his shotgun, racking a round before firing into the colonel once more, then grabs the toy, and flees.

The colonel could hold on no longer, collapsing into the blood-soaked mud.

"Bang—" "Bang—" "Bang—" "Bang—"

Using his last bit of strength, the colonel fires every round in his revolver, the pain is so great he can hardly tell where he's aiming.

He hopes for a miracle.

Colonel: Give her ... back to me ...

But it is in vain.

Far away, he sees a piece of paper fall out of the wind-up toy's mouth.

Colonel: Dear Colonel Bastos ...

Letter: I'm so glad to know that you're still alive. This news is even more exciting than that of your victory at sea many years ago!

Letter: As for me, my life remains largely the same. Old Cassia takes good care of me. I'm healthy and free from sickness. I'm just as you knew me, really. I love rather than hate; fight for freedom and oppose slavery; advocate for discussion over violence ...

Letter: I hope you are the same. Time won't turn us into someone else, I always believe that.

Letter: In fact, every time I look back at those tumultuous years, I feel another surge of emotion.

Letter: Your fight proved the supreme courage and devotion in your heart. You shed blood and sweat to protect peace, humanity and the honor of your country. Your efforts were not in vain, and your struggle is remembered by all.

Letter: Therefore, I will specially commend you, Colonel Bastos, and your regiment. You will soon receive a government pension that will ensure your security and prosperity for the rest of your life.

Letter: And a pure gold medal will be awarded to you at San Sebastian Square.

Letter: Please do attend the ceremony. I believe it will be a grand event.

Letter: I admit, I've grown to like the nickname. It is fitting after all.

Letter: Yours, Shorty

The colonel lies in the mud, reading the letter, pain searing through his body in equal reaction to the cold numbness.

Colonel: ...

Colonel: Silly girl.

Colonel: Shorty has been dead and buried for a long time.

Colonel: And I can't imagine he ever would have come around to that nickname.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310009

O, Mother

Ten years later

♪♫♪Fire cannot turn the past to ashes, even now.♪♫♪

Even now.

Even now.

Even now.

Elder I: The record's stuck. It just keeps repeating that last line.

Elder II: Stop hitting it. Doesn't matter how hard you hit the player, she isn't going to hop out and sing for you.

Elder I: What's the difference between her singing on the record and singing outside?

Elder II: Old fool, your brain must be broken.

Old Quitéria: Everyone, pack up, it's time to go.

A group of elders in black moves slowly toward the cemetery, with Old Quitéria at the front.

Each bends down, pressing their hands to their backs, and places their bouquets on the grave.

Old Quitéria: Old Cinder ... Old Jorge ... Old Otalia ... Old Dos ... Old Bastos ...

Lilies cover the freshly dug soil. The soul within awaits their song.

Old Quitéria leads the singing. As the colonel always said, short of an accordion, a good violinist and hymn leader is never in bad taste.

Elder I: Her voice is rough.

Elder II: Shh—quiet. She's doing the best she can for her age. Besides, she wasn't always the singer.

Elder I: Oh yeah? Who did it before her?

Elder III: Shh!

The elder in front turns with a frown, stopping their conversation,

as if stumbling over a long-unspoken no-man's land.

Elder II: You talking about Nala?

Elder I: Was her name Nala?

Elder II: Yes.

Elder I: They say she was here a long time ago, when this place was first built.

Elder I: She was found drifting down the river in a bamboo basket.

Elder II: I heard she had wings and flew down from the sky like an angel.

Elder IV: Nah, those weren't angel wings. They were demon wings! I heard she was a wanted criminal. Don't you know? The bounty was in the billions; you can't even imagine—!

Elder I: Oh, dear, what did she do?

Elder IV: Do you know the actress Lily Landry?

Elder I: Yes.

Elder IV: They say Nala assassinated her and was on the run from the government before hiding here.

Elder II: No way. They found the assassin; it wasn't her.

Elder II: I heard she was an international spy, selling information from here to there and there to here.

Old Quitéria: Quiet!

Old Quitéria approaches the whispering elders, the last ten years wore harsher on her face than any previous.

Old Quitéria: What are you all talking about anyways?

Elder II: Oi, Quitéria, were just talking about the previous hymn leader, most of us left never knew her.

Elder I: Yeah, you've been here the longest. You must remember. Tell us about her.

Old Quitéria: Nala?

Everyone nods.

Elder I: Yes, who was she, what's her story? Come on, Quitéria, you must know something.

Old Quitéria pauses, then sighs.

Old Quitéria: She ...

Trying to remember isn't easy, she wades through memories that have grown thick as tropical foliage.

But patience brings a reward, a memory of joy and laughter.

Old Quitéria: She always knows what we need.

No one pries further.

Quitéria ...

Old Quitéria looks up to the sky. It is as if seeing an angel descending from above.

The answers flood back to her with a rose-colored glow.

Old Quitéria: Caramba, what is happening? I just bought these chickens from the market the other day, and now they're all gone! That's the third time this month!

Caregiver: Calm down. Probably some mangy dog sneaking in during the night.

Old Quitéria: We'll see about that! I'm going to find out just who's responsible tonight.

Caregiver: Be careful you don't get bitten by a weasel. Those things can swallow a whole chicken without leaving a trace.

Old Quitéria: We had a weasel problem back home; I caught it in a week. They're no trouble.

Caregiver: Then go ahead. Everyone's still waiting to try your chicken stew.

Night falls. Old Quitéria stays awake, waiting for any movement in the chicken coop.

Finally, the first chicken's squawk sends her rushing to the coop.

Old Quitéria holds a lantern, searching the ink-black night for the source of the commotion.

In the dim light, she sees a disheveled girl with a chicken's foot sticking out from her mouth.

Old Quitéria: So, you're the little weasel stealing our chickens.

Blood drips from the girl's mouth. Quitéria couldn't tell if it is the chicken's or her own.

Anjo Nala: ...!

The girl yanks the chicken claw out of her mouth, wincing in pain.

Old Quitéria: Ei! Don't do that.

Anjo Nala: ...!!!

In a flash, the girl extends her claws, pinning Old Quitéria against the wall.

Anjo Nala: *pant*

Anjo Nala: Are you going to lock me in a cage?

Old Quitéria: Oh—oh—don't do this, child. Please, don't be afraid. I'll do nothing of the sort. I just wanted to know what was happening to the chickens!

The girl stares suspiciously into Quitéria's eyes.

Old Quitéria: Look, I'm unarmed, and I'm old. I couldn't catch you even if I tried.

Old Quitéria: Believe me, I only came to check on the chickens. In fact, until now, I thought you were only a dog.

The girl releases her grip, then makes a quick retreat toward the corner, hiding the rest of the chicken in a bundle under her arms.

Seeing Old Quitéria make no further moves, she begins devouring the chicken again.

Old Quitéria: ...

Old Quitéria slowly approaches.

Old Quitéria: Hi ...

She reaches out, trying to touch the girl's head.

The girl trembles, baring her fangs at the aged midwife.

Old Quitéria: Hiss—!!!

Old Quitéria stops, her hand hovering in the air.

Then, as if making a decision ...

She continues, until her hand falls on the girl's head.

The girl jumps up and bites her.

Blood oozes from the wound.

Old Quitéria: Ow! That hurts.

But the woman squints, enduring the pain.

Until it begins to ease little by little as the fangs retract from her skin.

The girl lets go.

And Quitéria returns her hand to the girl's head once more.

Old Quitéria: Eat girl. Eat more, you look starved.

The girl stares at Quitéria, then lowers her head and quickly finishes the chicken.

She kneels, and wipes the girl's face clean.

Old Quitéria: We don't dine with our hands here.

Old Quitéria: It seems you have much to learn about proper etiquette. But I can teach you. If you'll let me.

Old Quitéria hands the girl a handkerchief.

Old Quitéria: What do you say? Will you be our new caregiver?

The girl's eyes are fixed on Old Quitéria.

After a long while, she sniffles.

Anjo Nala: Will it be warmer inside?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310010

...

...

Beautiful.

Beautiful, infinite.

Beautiful, infinite, expansive, converging.

Leaping, mottled, piercing, striking to the bone.

Mine, yours.

The future's.

...

Empty.

Empty?

Empty.

Empty, empty—empty!

Empty.

Empty.

…

…

… Gulp …

Gulp, gurgle … gulp, thump, thump … thump, thump, thump—

Bang—!

Anjo Nala: …

Anjo Nala: …

Anjo Nala: …!